also became a way for India to strike a balance with Pakistan. Despite 'genuine non-alignment' being a major political issue in the 1977 general elections that saw the fall of Indira Gandhi and rise of the Janata Party, New Delhi was highly dependent on the Soviet Union after 1971. Though New Delhi's concerns about the US-China-Pakistan-Iran axis were valid, its stand on the Afghan question reflected India's incapacity to question Soviet policies. What remained constant throughout this period was the Kabuliwallah connection i.e. the 'consensus'—or political will—in New Delhi to retain close bilateral ties with Kabul regardless of latter's political and economic woes. The Soviet military intervention, however, challenged even this foundational cultural tenet of India-Afghanistan bilateral relations. From now on, instead of being viewed as a 'friend of Afghanistan', India came to be seen as friend of one or the other political or ethnic faction, or simply a reluctant neighbour. And this was just the beginning of a long war.